

Impact: High Difficulty: Easy-Medium Misuse risk: It fails when you treat every bid as either an interruption to reject or a full conversation to enter

CORE FORMULA

Notice: this is a bid, not background noise. -> **Name or join:** "That sounds exciting," "That looks frustrating," "Show me," "I saw this." -> **Follow through:** ask one relevant question, celebrate, help, laugh with them, or schedule a return. -> **Calibrate:** watch whether they relax, expand, smile, clarify, or pull back. -> **Minimum viable sentence:** "I saw that - tell me the important part." -> **Boundary version:** "I want to turn toward this, but not while I finish this. Can I come back in ten minutes?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Look up or reply, name the signal in ordinary language, and add one small follow-through - or, if you cannot respond well now, acknowledge the bid and schedule a clean return.

BEST FOR

- Everyday relationships where warmth depends on repeated small contact.
- Team settings where people share updates, concerns, wins, and informal signals.
- Digital conversations where ignoring a bid can feel colder than intended.
- Moments when someone is testing whether it is safe to share more.
- Repairing a pattern of distraction, abruptness, or emotional absence.
- Parenting, friendship, partnership, mentoring, client care, and leadership.

PHRASE BANK

Fast acknowledgement · Quick one-liners

- "I saw that."
- "Show me."
- "That sounds like it mattered."
- "I hear the concern under that."
- "Nice - what changed?"
- "Say the headline."
- "Sorry, what? Say that again."
- "I saw that - tell me the important part."

Social and humour bids · Warmth and connection

- "Wait, that sounds interesting. What happened?"
- "I heard the excitement in that. Tell me the win."
- "That was a bid for a laugh, and I missed it. Try me again."
- "I can see why you wanted to show me that."
- "That is exactly your kind of humour."
- "That looks like a good moment."
- "I nearly missed that. That was good."
- "Show me. What do you like about it?"

Join the bid · One light follow-up

- "What should I notice?"
- "What was the best part?"
- "What made that frustrating?"
- "That sounds like a signal. What should we not miss?"
- "That sounds like a real win. What part felt best?"

- "I hear a concern under that. What should we slow down and look at?"
- "What did you do differently this time?"
- "Show me - what am I looking at?"

Professional and effort signals · Work, status, and updates

- "I hear there is a concern under that. What should I not miss?"
- "That update sounds like it took real effort. What changed?"
- "I saw your note. Before we move on, what do you need from me?"
- "That sounds like a small signal of a bigger issue. Is that right?"
- "I want to give this more than a halfway answer. Can we put ten minutes on it?"
- "I saw this. I cannot answer fully yet, but I do want to come back to it."
- "That is worth more than a reaction emoji. Give me a little time to reply properly."
- "I missed this earlier. Thanks for sending it. What mattered most to you here?"

Busy moments and timing boundaries · Warmth plus a clear limit

- "I cannot pause fully, but I heard the concern. Say the headline."
- "I am focused on the deadline, not ignoring you. Give me the key signal."
- "I want to respond well. The cleanest time is after this meeting."
- "I want to hear this properly. I cannot do it well right now. Can we come back at 3?"
- "I can give this five real minutes after the call."
- "I want to answer that, and I am at capacity. Can I respond after dinner?"
- "I want to turn toward this, but not while I finish this task. Can I come back in ten minutes?"
- "I want to hear it properly. I am finishing this, then I can give you five minutes."

Repair and return · After a missed or fumbled bid

- "I missed that. Say it again - I want to catch it."
- "I was distracted and gave you nothing back. What were you showing me?"
- "I treated that as small. It sounds like it mattered."
- "That came out too abrupt. I do want to hear the point."
- "I turned away too fast. Say that again."
- "I gave you a logistics answer when you were asking for presence. Let me try again."
- "I jumped to fixing. Let me first understand why this mattered."
- "I missed that because I was distracted. I want to catch it - say it again?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Someone shares a small win: "Cool," while looking away.
Better: "Nice - what changed?"
Best: "That sounds like a real win. What part felt best?"
- Weak: Someone hints at a concern: "Anyway, next item."
Better: "Sounds like there is a concern there."
Best: "I hear a concern under that. What should we slow down and look at?"
- Weak: You are busy: no response, or a flat "later."
Better: "Busy, later."
Best: "I want to hear it properly. I am finishing this, then I can give you five minutes."
- Weak: You missed the bid: pretend you did not.
Better: "Sorry, what?"
Best: "I missed that because I was distracted. I want to catch it - say it again?"

DECISION TREE

If Someone made a small reach - a comment, look, joke, update, question, or sigh.

Treat it as a real bid. Do not dismiss it as noise, and do not invent one that is not there.

"I saw that - tell me the important part."

If The bid is unsafe, coercive, or wrong for this setting.

Set a respectful boundary instead of turning toward it.
"I am not available for this here."

If You cannot give real attention right now.

Acknowledge the bid and schedule a clean return - then keep it.
"I want to hear this properly. Can we come back at 3?"

If You can respond now - match the type of bid.

Win: celebrate. Concern: validate. Humour: join. Help: clarify. Presence: slow down and show attention.
"Nice - what changed?"

If You are unsure whether your response landed.

Check rather than assume, and adjust with a recovery line if you misread it.
"Did I catch the right thing?"

If The bid keeps repeating in a way that drains or pressures you.

Combine warmth with a clear limit rather than granting more access.
"I care about this, and I also need a clear time boundary."

SCENARIOS

A partner, friend, or family member shows you something small.

Pause enough to actually receive it before you move on. — "Show me. What do you like about it?"

A colleague hints that a project issue is bothering them.

Treat the side comment as a possible concern, not a debate to win. — "That sounds like a signal. What should we not miss?"

A direct report shares a tiny win.

Acknowledge the win and the effort, not just the output. — "Nice. What did you do differently this time?"

A friend sends a meme or photo.

Respond to the bid for contact, not just the file. — "That is exactly your kind of humour."

A child asks you to watch something.

Give a real window or a clear promise, not a vague "in a minute." — "I can watch one now. Show me the part you want me to see."

You are overloaded when a bid arrives.

Acknowledge plus boundary, so warmth does not curdle into resentment. — "I want to answer that, and I am at capacity. Can I respond after dinner?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The bid is unsafe, coercive, harassing, or boundary-violating.
- You are exhausted enough that a fake warm response would be dishonest.
- A crisis requires direct action rather than relational expansion.
- The other person has asked for space.
- A repeated bid is actually a demand for constant access.
- The setting requires privacy, confidentiality, or role boundaries.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the bids

Through the day, catch three small bids - live, digital, work, or home. Just write down each signal: a comment, look, joke, update, sigh, or photo. Noticing is the whole task.

Day 2 — Name the type

For yesterday's bids and three new ones, label each type: attention, celebration, concern, humour, help, reassurance, presence, or shared focus. Matching the type is how you avoid stock warmth.

Day 3 — Toward, away, or against

For each bid today, record whether you turned toward, away, or against it. No judgement - you are building an honest picture of your default reaction.

Day 4 — One-sentence turns

Practise the minimum viable move: on three real bids, give one clear turn-toward sentence and then stop. Notice how a short, matched response often does more than a long one.

Day 5 — Boundary plus warmth

Twice today, acknowledge a bid you cannot fully take right now and schedule a clean return - then keep it. Try: "I want to hear this properly. Can we come back at 3?"

Day 6 — Repair a miss

Find one bid you ignored, dismissed, or over-entered, and repair it cleanly: "I treated that as small - it sounds like it mattered." Return without defensiveness.

Day 7 — Live reps and score

With a partner (or in real conversations), respond to five small bids, one sentence each. Score yourself 0-3: 0 missed, 1 generic, 2 matched the type, 3 matched the type, respected timing, and calibrated.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- What small bids did I notice - and which did I miss because I was busy, anxious, or self-focused?
- Did I turn toward without overcommitting?
- Did I respond to the actual bid type, or give a stock answer?
- Did I turn a bid into advice, one-upping, interrogation, or a story about me?
- Did I set boundaries cleanly when I could not respond - and return when I said I would?
- What is one bid I can repair now?